What does this mean for the future of the group? Specifically, is it poised to become the new al-Qaeda, as some analysts suggest? In Lashkar's present incarnation the short answer is no. The propensity to analogize it to al-Qaeda is understandable to the degree that both have transnational attack capabilities and grand ambitions. It also may result from the tendency to view the next potential 'big threat' through the prism of the present one. However, as this book has attempted to illustrate, Lashkar is its own unique organization and, to paraphrase one of Clausewitz's many famous dictums about war, we must not mistake it for nor try to turn it into something that it is not.[7]

Unlike al-Qaeda Central (the core organization hiding in Pakistan's Tribal Areas), which confronts a challenging security environment and relies heavily on other outfits for assistance with launching attacks, Lashkar controls a robust infrastructure that operates in plain sight. Its leadership operates out of Lahore and Pakistan-administered Kashmir, not from a hidden redoubt somewhere along the Afghanistan-Pakistan border, though the group has increased it presence there. This freedom of movement carries with it a number of benefits the core al-Qaeda organization does not enjoy, but also serves as a leverage point that can be used to constrain Lashkar's activity. The leadership's ongoing relationship with the ISI and susceptibility to state pressure robs it of legitimacy in the eyes of some jihadis, who respect the sacrifices al-Qaeda leaders have made and the forthright manner in which they challenge the US as well as its many allies. At present, Lashkar or at least significant elements within it, are still 'tamed by the ISI' as one former member observed.[8] The group no longer needs financial or much operational support; rather it requires protection and the freedom to continue its military as well as social welfare activities. In the 1990s the group needed the state to build up its infrastructure, whereas now it is reliant on the army and ISI not to tear it down. It is worth highlighting Lashkar's devotion to dawa through the delivering of social services—a capacity al-Qaeda lacks—and the fact that protecting its domestic infrastructure has at times limited its military adventurism.

Regional dynamics also continue to exert considerable and direct influence on Lashkar's behavior. The leadership retains an element of nationalism that is distinctly at odds with al-Qaeda and still finds common ground, as it has since the 1990s, with elements in the army and ISI. The two remain co-dependent: each afraid of the repercussions that might stem